

The Washington Post

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RE V1 V2 V3 V4

An a.m. shower 51/37 • Tomorrow: Windier 49/33 B6 Democracy Dies in Darkness MONDAY, APRIL 7, 2025 • \$4

Fears rise as safety agencies hollowed

From food to weather, ex-officials warn of ‘next crisis waiting to happen’

BY DAN DIAMOND AND HANNAH NATANSON

Somewhere on a grocery shelf, or in a restaurant, or on a food-factory floor in America, lurk bacteria that haven’t been detected yet. Perhaps *E. coli*, which is linked with food poisoning, or more of the *cronobacter* that led to infant illnesses, sparked a nationwide shortage of infant formula in 2022 and led to major reforms at the Food and Drug Administration.

The task of finding those bacteria rests on FDA inspectors, whose jobs have been mostly preserved amid the Trump administration’s sweeping cuts to the federal government. But the people who help support those inspections haven’t fared so well. More than 150 people in the FDA’s Office of Inspections and Investigations — the staff responsible for purchasing supplies, managing trips and coordinating other administrative functions — were laid off last week, according to multiple federal officials. So were staff dedicated to food-safety policies and regulations, including an entire office that partnered with foreign countries to handle food-related disease outbreaks. Meanwhile, the FDA’s top food safety official — a position created after the infant formula

SEE TRUMP ON A4

NIH layoffs are hindering cancer trial’s leap forward

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON

Scientists at the National Institutes of Health demonstrated a promising step toward using a person’s own immune cells to fight gastrointestinal cancers in a paper in Nature Medicine on Tuesday, the same day the agency was hit with devastating layoffs that left many NIH personnel in tears.

The treatment approach is still early in its development; the personalized immunotherapy regimen shrank tumors in only about a quarter of the patients with colon, rectal and other GI cancers enrolled in a clinical trial. But a researcher who was not involved in the study called the results “remarkable” because they highlight a path to a frustratingly elusive goal in medicine — harnessing a person’s own immune defenses to target common solid tumor cancers.

Until now, cell-based immunotherapy has worked mainly on blood cancers, such as leukemia, but not the solid cancers that seed tumors in the breast, brain, lungs,

SEE NIH ON A4

Measles death: Kennedy Jr. visits Texas after a second child dies. A3



Alex Ovechkin is mobbed by Capitals teammates after scoring the 895th goal of his career to surpass Wayne Gretzky’s NHL record.

Ovechkin over all

The captain of the Capitals is now hockey’s greatest scorer. He is also Washington’s — forever.



Barry Svrluga

COLUMN

ELMONT, N.Y. — He is 39, but at that moment Sunday afternoon, he became a kid on a pond again, slinging a puck into the back of the net, then belly flopping onto the ice, sliding over the blue line in delirium. Alex Ovechkin established himself as a goal scorer without peer. There’s no point in acting your age.

With a sizzling wrist shot — so appropriately on the power play, so appropriately from just outside the left faceoff circle — the Washington Capitals’ absolute icon beat a New York Islanders

Chasing Gretzky
Alex Ovechkin now holds the NHL career goals record.

895

Ovechkin stands alone
The Capitals star passes Wayne Gretzky with his 895th goal. D1

‘Unbreakable’
Presale for our book on Ovechkin’s chase is live at wapo.st/capitals.

goalie named Ilya Sorokin, a fellow Russian. In a box above the ice at UBS Arena, Wayne Gretzky rose from his chair and clapped. For the first time in 11,338 days, Gretzky did not hold the NHL’s record for goals. Ovechkin did.

“They say records are made to be broken,” Gretzky told the crowd, facing Ovechkin, a few moments later. “But I’m not sure who’s going to get more goals than that.”

That would be 895. Eight hundred ninety-five.

“This is something crazy,” Ovechkin said afterward. “I’m probably going to need a couple more days or maybe a couple weeks

SEE SVRLUGA ON A6

Amid anti-DEI push, agency edits history exhibits

National Park Service websites have changed the way they describe subjects from slavery to Jim Crow

BY JON SWAINE AND JEREMY B. MERRILL

For years, a National Park Service webpage introduced the Underground Railroad with a large photograph of its most famous “conductor,” Harriet Tubman. “The Underground Railroad — the resistance to enslavement through escape and flight, through the end of the Civil War — refers to the efforts of enslaved African Americans to gain their freedom by escaping bondage,” the page began.

Tubman’s photograph is now gone. In its place are images of Postal Service stamps that highlight “Black/White cooperation” in the secret network and that feature Tubman among abolitionists of both races.

The introductory sentence is gone, too. It has been replaced by a line that makes no mention of slavery and that describes the Underground Railroad as “one of the most significant expressions

SEE PARKS ON A8

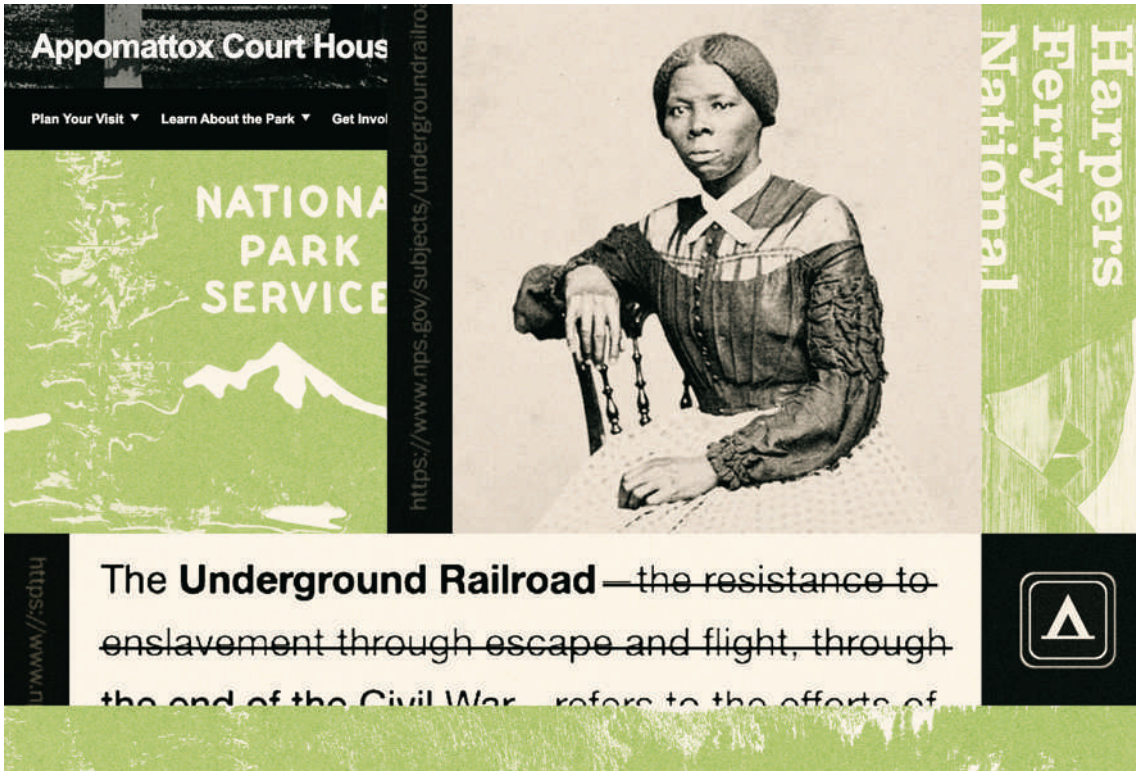


ILLUSTRATION BY LUCY NALAND/THE WASHINGTON POST; LIBRARY OF CONGRESS; NATIONAL PARK SERVICE; ISTOCK

Officials hold the line on tariffs

TRUMP TELLS PUBLIC TO ‘HANG TOUGH’

Pushback comes from across political spectrum

BY GERRIT DE VYNCK, MAEGAN VAZQUEZ, MARÍA LUISA PAUL AND CAROLINE O’DONOVAN

Trump administration officials blitzed television networks Sunday to defend the president’s massive tariffs that have caused a sell-off in the stock market and triggered recession fears, arguing that the import taxes are already forcing dozens of countries to come to the bargaining table.

Fifty countries were “burning the phone lines into the White House” to negotiate with President Donald Trump, Agriculture Secretary Brooke Rollins told CNN’s “State of the Union.” Don’t panic, White House senior counselor Peter Navarro said on Fox News’s “Sunday Morning Futures.” And Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, speaking on NBC’s “Meet the Press,” dismissed predictions from economists and banks that there would be a recession.

The full-court press from Cabinet members and advisers came as the administration is under immense pressure to pull back on the tariffs, which have caused the biggest loss in American stock market wealth since the panicked

SEE TARIFFS ON A9

Numerous failures cited in deadly hit on U.S. base

BY ALEX HORTON

A drone attack that killed three U.S. soldiers in Jordan last year was most likely preventable, according to a military investigation that determined that numerous failures — from complacency and indecisiveness to outright negligence — contributed to the worst assault on American troops since the fall of Afghanistan.

The small outpost, known as Tower 22, is along Jordan’s border with Syria and Iraq, and largely had been spared from the assaults on American positions in those countries by Iranian proxies furious with the United States for its support of Israel’s war in the Gaza Strip.

However, on the morning of Jan. 28, 2024, while most of the base’s 350 troops slept, there were indications an attack might be imminent, Army investigators learned.

An intelligence report transmitted to Tower 22 approximately 90 minutes before the strike warned that militia groups had discussed openly on social media their intent to target U.S. forces in the area, prompting Tower

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THE CHASE IS OVER

CONGRATULATIONS OVI

